



MHM RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Destination Attributes, Tourist Satisfaction, and Behavioral Intentions of International Tourists in Nepal

A Structural Equation Modeling Approach

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Name of Student

NATHM

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1 Introduction

Tourism has become one of the fastest-growing economic sectors worldwide and plays a significant role in promoting economic growth, employment generation, cultural exchange, and sustainable development. According to the United Nations Tourism Organization (UN Tourism), international tourist arrivals have recovered strongly after the COVID-19 pandemic, demonstrating the resilience and increasing importance of the tourism industry in the global economy (UN Tourism, 2024b). Tourism contributes substantially to national income, foreign exchange earnings, infrastructure development, and poverty reduction, particularly in developing countries where tourism is recognized as a strategic sector for economic diversification and regional development (World Bank, 2024b; Asian Development Bank, 2024a).

Nepal is internationally recognized as one of the world's most attractive tourist destinations because of its unique combination of natural beauty, cultural heritage, religious significance, biodiversity, and adventure tourism opportunities. The country is home to Mount Everest, eight of the world's fourteen highest mountains, ten UNESCO World Heritage Sites, diverse ethnic cultures, and numerous pilgrimage destinations. These distinctive attractions have positioned Nepal as a preferred destination for trekking, mountaineering, wildlife tourism, spiritual tourism, and cultural exploration (Nepal Tourism Board, 2025; Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, 2024).

The tourism industry is one of the major contributors to Nepal's economy through employment generation, foreign currency earnings, local enterprise development, and regional economic growth. Recent statistics indicate a steady increase in international tourist arrivals following the pandemic, reflecting the growing confidence of international travelers in Nepal as a tourism destination (Nepal Tourism Board, 2025). The Government of Nepal has also identified tourism as a priority sector for sustainable economic development by improving tourism infrastructure, enhancing service quality, promoting destination branding, and encouraging private sector participation (Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, 2025). Similarly, the World Bank and the Asian Development Bank have emphasized that improvements in transportation infrastructure, tourism services, destination management, and institutional capacity are essential for strengthening Nepal's tourism competitiveness in the international market (World Bank, 2024a; Asian Development Bank, 2024b).

In today's highly competitive tourism market, attracting tourists alone is insufficient for ensuring long-term destination success. Tourism destinations must also provide memorable and satisfying experiences that encourage visitors to revisit the destination and recommend it to others. Previous studies have consistently reported that destination attributes such as destination attractiveness, service quality, accessibility, safety and security, and perceived price significantly influence tourists' overall satisfaction and subsequent behavioral intentions (Chen and Tsai, 2007; Chi and Qu, 2008; Yoon and Uysal, 2005; Žabkar et al., 2010; Eusébio and Vieira, 2013). Tourist satisfaction has therefore become one of the most important indicators of destination competitiveness because satisfied tourists are more likely to revisit a destination, recommend it to others, and generate positive word-of-mouth communication (Prayag, 2009; Stylos et al., 2016; Prayag et al., 2017).

Behavioral intentions represent tourists' future behavioral responses after experiencing

a destination. These intentions are commonly reflected through revisit intention, recommendation intention, and positive word-of-mouth communication. Previous empirical studies have shown that tourist satisfaction acts as a mediating mechanism through which destination attributes influence behavioral intentions (Assaker et al., 2011; Rasoolimanesh et al., 2022; Thapa et al., 2025). Consequently, understanding how destination attributes shape tourist satisfaction and future behavioral intentions has become an important research area in tourism and hospitality management.

Although numerous international studies have investigated the relationships among destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions, empirical evidence from Nepal remains relatively limited. Existing studies conducted in Nepal have mainly focused on tourist satisfaction, service quality, destination image, or revisit intention separately, often using descriptive statistics or conventional regression techniques (Bam and Kunwar, 2020; Baniya et al., 2017; Bhattarai et al., 2025). Few studies have simultaneously examined multiple destination attributes and their direct and indirect effects on behavioral intentions through tourist satisfaction using Structural Equation Modeling (SEM). Moreover, important destination characteristics such as accessibility, safety and security, price perception, and destination attractiveness have received comparatively less empirical attention within the Nepalese tourism context.

Furthermore, the rapid recovery of international tourism after the COVID-19 pandemic has changed tourists' expectations regarding service quality, safety, accessibility, and overall travel experience. These changing expectations require updated empirical evidence to assist tourism planners, destination managers, hotel operators, travel agencies, and policymakers in improving Nepal's tourism competitiveness and visitor experiences (Jeong and Kim, 2021; UN Tourism, 2024a). Understanding the determinants of tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions is therefore essential for developing evidence-based tourism policies that encourage repeat visitation, strengthen destination loyalty, and improve Nepal's international tourism image.

Therefore, this study proposes to examine the influence of destination attributes, namely destination attractiveness, service quality, price perception, accessibility, and safety and security, on tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions among international tourists visiting Nepal. Tourist satisfaction is considered as the mediating construct, while tourist characteristics and travel characteristics are incorporated as control variables. The findings of this study are expected to contribute to tourism literature by extending the empirical understanding of tourist behavior in the Nepalese context and provide practical recommendations for policymakers and tourism stakeholders to improve destination competitiveness and sustainable tourism development.

2 Rationale of the Study

Tourism has become one of the most competitive industries globally, requiring destinations not only to attract visitors but also to provide high-quality experiences that encourage repeat visitation and positive word-of-mouth. In the contemporary tourism market, tourists have numerous destination choices, making tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions critical determinants of destination competitiveness and long-term sustainability (Chen and Tsai, 2007; Chi and Qu, 2008; Yoon and Uysal, 2005).

Nepal possesses exceptional tourism resources, including the Himalayan mountain range, rich biodiversity, diverse cultural heritage, religious pilgrimage sites, adventure tourism opportunities, and unique indigenous traditions. These attractions have enabled Nepal to establish itself as a prominent destination for international tourists. Despite these comparative advantages, Nepal continues to face several challenges related to service quality, transportation infrastructure, destination accessibility, safety, sanitation, information services, and tourism management, which may influence tourists' overall experiences and future travel decisions (Nepal Tourism Board, 2025; Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, 2024; World Bank, 2024b).

The Government of Nepal has identified tourism as one of the priority sectors for achieving sustainable economic growth, employment generation, and foreign exchange earnings. Recent tourism statistics indicate that international tourist arrivals have increased significantly following the recovery from the COVID-19 pandemic. However, increasing tourist arrivals alone does not guarantee sustainable tourism development. Long-term success depends on tourists' satisfaction with their travel experiences and their willingness to revisit Nepal and recommend it to others (UN Tourism, 2024b; Nepal Tourism Board, 2025).

Previous tourism studies have consistently demonstrated that destination attributes, including destination attractiveness, service quality, accessibility, safety and security, and price perception, significantly influence tourist satisfaction, which subsequently affects behavioral intentions such as revisit intention and recommendation intention (Žabkar et al., 2010; Eusébio and Vieira, 2013; Prayag et al., 2017; Rasoolimanesh et al., 2022). Tourist satisfaction therefore serves as an important psychological mechanism through which tourists evaluate their travel experiences and develop future behavioral responses toward a destination.

Although considerable international literature exists on destination attributes and tourist behavior, empirical studies in Nepal remain relatively limited. Existing Nepalese studies have generally focused on individual aspects such as tourist satisfaction, destination image, hotel service quality, or revisit intention independently (Bam and Kunwar, 2020; Baniya et al., 2017; Bhattarai et al., 2025; Thapa et al., 2025). Few studies have simultaneously examined the combined effects of multiple destination attributes on behavioral intentions through the mediating role of tourist satisfaction using Structural Equation Modeling (SEM). Consequently, there is insufficient empirical evidence regarding the complex relationships among these constructs within the Nepalese tourism context.

Moreover, the expectations of international tourists have evolved considerably in recent years. Besides natural attractions, tourists increasingly emphasize service quality, destination safety, convenient accessibility, fair pricing, environmental sustainability, and memorable travel experiences when evaluating tourism destinations (Jeong and Kim, 2021; Stylos et al., 2016). Understanding these evolving expectations is essential for tourism stakeholders to formulate effective destination management strategies and improve Nepal's competitiveness in the international tourism market.

The findings of this study are expected to provide both theoretical and practical contributions. Theoretically, the study will extend the existing literature by developing and empirically testing an integrated conceptual framework linking destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions in the context of Nepal. The study will

also contribute to tourism behavior literature by validating the mediating role of tourist satisfaction while controlling for tourists' demographic and travel characteristics.

Practically, the findings will provide valuable insights for policymakers, the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, the Nepal Tourism Board, destination management organizations, hotel operators, travel agencies, and other tourism entrepreneurs. The empirical evidence generated from this study can assist these stakeholders in improving tourism products, enhancing service quality, strengthening destination marketing strategies, and formulating evidence-based tourism policies aimed at increasing tourist satisfaction, encouraging repeat visitation, and promoting positive destination recommendations. Ultimately, these improvements will contribute to strengthening Nepal's tourism competitiveness and supporting sustainable tourism development.

3 Significance of the Study

This study is expected to make significant theoretical, practical, managerial, and policy contributions to tourism and hospitality research in Nepal. By examining the relationships among destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions, the study will generate empirical evidence that can support both academic research and tourism development initiatives.

From a theoretical perspective, this study will contribute to the growing body of tourism literature by integrating destination attractiveness, service quality, price perception, accessibility, and safety and security into a single conceptual framework. While previous studies have examined these constructs individually, relatively few studies have simultaneously investigated their combined effects on tourist behavioral intentions through the mediating role of tourist satisfaction in the Nepalese context (Chen and Tsai, 2007; Chi and Qu, 2008; Žabkar et al., 2010; Rasoolimanesh et al., 2022). The findings will therefore enhance the understanding of international tourist behavior and validate the applicability of established tourism theories in Nepal.

Methodologically, this research will employ Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) to examine both direct and indirect relationships among latent constructs. Compared with conventional statistical techniques, SEM allows the simultaneous estimation of measurement and structural models, providing a more comprehensive understanding of the relationships among destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions (Hair et al., 2022; Kline, 2023). The study is expected to provide a useful methodological reference for future tourism and hospitality researchers conducting multivariate analysis.

Practically, the findings of this study will provide valuable information for tourism entrepreneurs, hotel operators, travel agencies, trekking companies, tour guides, destination management organizations, and other tourism service providers. By identifying the destination attributes that have the greatest influence on tourist satisfaction and future behavioral intentions, tourism businesses can improve service quality, develop customer-oriented products, enhance visitor experiences, and strengthen destination competitiveness. Improved tourist satisfaction is likely to encourage repeat visitation, positive word-of-mouth communication, and destination loyalty, all of which contribute to sustainable tourism growth (Prayag et al., 2017; Stylos et al., 2016).

The study will also have important policy implications. The empirical findings can assist

the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation (MoCTCA), the Nepal Tourism Board (NTB), provincial governments, and local tourism authorities in designing evidence-based tourism policies and destination management strategies. The results will help policymakers identify priority areas for investment, including transportation infrastructure, destination accessibility, visitor safety, service quality improvement, and tourism marketing. These improvements are expected to enhance Nepal's competitiveness in the international tourism market and support the country's long-term tourism development goals (Nepal Tourism Board, 2025; Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, 2024; World Bank, 2024b; Asian Development Bank, 2024a).

Furthermore, the study will provide valuable insights for local communities and tourism-related enterprises by highlighting the importance of maintaining high-quality tourism services and preserving natural and cultural resources. Increased tourist satisfaction and positive behavioral intentions can lead to higher tourist retention, greater tourism expenditure, enhanced employment opportunities, and improved livelihoods for local communities. These outcomes directly support the principles of sustainable tourism development advocated by international organizations such as UN Tourism and the Asian Development Bank (UN Tourism, 2024b; Asian Development Bank, 2024b).

Finally, this study will serve as a useful reference for future researchers, postgraduate students, and academicians interested in tourism marketing, destination management, hospitality management, and consumer behavior. The proposed conceptual framework and empirical findings may be extended or replicated in other tourism destinations within Nepal or in comparable developing countries, thereby enriching the literature on destination competitiveness and tourist behavioral intentions.

4 Statement of the Problem

Tourism is one of the major contributors to Nepal's economy, generating employment opportunities, foreign exchange earnings, and regional economic development. Nepal is internationally recognized for its diverse tourism resources, including the Himalayan mountain range, UNESCO World Heritage Sites, rich cultural diversity, religious pilgrimage destinations, wildlife reserves, and adventure tourism activities. In recent years, the tourism sector has experienced substantial growth following the recovery from the COVID-19 pandemic, with increasing numbers of international tourist arrivals (Nepal Tourism Board, 2025; UN Tourism, 2024b). The Government of Nepal has also identified tourism as a priority sector for achieving sustainable economic development and improving the country's international competitiveness (Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, 2024; Asian Development Bank, 2024b).

Despite these favorable developments, Nepal continues to face several challenges that affect the quality of tourists' experiences. Issues related to transportation infrastructure, destination accessibility, service quality, sanitation, safety and security, tourism information, environmental management, and pricing remain significant concerns for many international visitors (World Bank, 2024b; Asian Development Bank, 2024a). These challenges may reduce tourists' overall satisfaction and negatively influence their intentions to revisit Nepal or recommend the destination to others.

The tourism literature consistently suggests that destination attributes play a vital role in

shaping tourists' perceptions and experiences. Attributes such as destination attractiveness, service quality, accessibility, safety and security, and price perception significantly influence tourist satisfaction, which subsequently determines behavioral intentions including revisit intention and recommendation intention (Chen and Tsai, 2007; Chi and Qu, 2008; Yoon and Uysal, 2005; Žabkar et al., 2010). Tourist satisfaction has therefore become an important indicator of destination competitiveness because satisfied tourists are more likely to become loyal visitors and promote destinations through positive word-of-mouth communication (Prayag et al., 2017; Stylos et al., 2016).

Although extensive international research has examined the relationships among destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions, empirical evidence from Nepal remains limited. Existing studies have primarily focused on specific tourism products, hotel service quality, destination image, or tourist satisfaction independently using descriptive analysis or conventional regression techniques (Bam and Kunwar, 2020; Baniya et al., 2017; Bhattarai et al., 2025). Very few studies have developed and empirically tested an integrated structural model that simultaneously examines the influence of multiple destination attributes on tourists' behavioral intentions through the mediating role of tourist satisfaction using Structural Equation Modeling (SEM).

Furthermore, international tourists visiting Nepal differ considerably in terms of demographic characteristics, travel motivations, travel experiences, and expectations. Tourist characteristics such as age, nationality, education, and income, as well as travel characteristics including purpose of visit, length of stay, accommodation type, and travel companion, may also influence tourists' perceptions and behavioral intentions. However, these variables have received limited attention as control variables in previous Nepalese tourism studies.

The absence of comprehensive empirical evidence limits the ability of policymakers, destination managers, tourism entrepreneurs, and hospitality service providers to formulate effective strategies for improving tourist experiences and strengthening Nepal's tourism competitiveness. Therefore, there is a need to develop and validate an integrated conceptual framework that examines the relationships among destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions of international tourists in Nepal while controlling for tourist and travel characteristics.

5 Research Questions

The study seeks to answer the following research questions:

1. How do destination attributes influence the satisfaction of international tourists visiting Nepal?
2. Does tourist satisfaction significantly influence tourists' behavioral intentions, including revisit intention and recommendation intention?
3. Does tourist satisfaction mediate the relationship between destination attributes and behavioral intentions?
4. Do tourist characteristics and travel characteristics significantly influence tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions?

6 Objectives

6.1 General Objective

The general objective of this study is to examine the influence of destination attributes on the behavioral intentions of international tourists in Nepal through the mediating role of tourist satisfaction.

6.2 Specific Objectives

The specific objectives of the study are:

1. To examine the effect of destination attributes (destination attractiveness, service quality, price perception, accessibility, and safety & security) on tourist satisfaction among international tourists visiting Nepal.
2. To assess the effect of tourist satisfaction on the behavioral intentions (revisit intention and recommendation intention) of international tourists in Nepal.
3. To examine the mediating role of tourist satisfaction in the relationship between destination attributes and behavioral intentions.
4. To examine whether tourist characteristics (age, gender, nationality, education, and income) significantly influence tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions.
5. To examine whether travel characteristics (purpose of visit, length of stay, accommodation, and travel companion) significantly influence tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions.

7 Literature Review

7.1 Introduction

A comprehensive review of the literature is an essential component of any scientific research because it establishes the theoretical and empirical foundation of the study. It enables researchers to understand existing knowledge, identify research gaps, develop appropriate conceptual frameworks, and formulate research hypotheses. In tourism and hospitality research, the literature review provides insights into the factors influencing tourists' perceptions, experiences, satisfaction, and subsequent behavioral intentions. By synthesizing previous studies, researchers can better understand the relationships among key constructs and justify the need for further investigation (Kline, 2023; Hair et al., 2022).

The tourism industry has become increasingly competitive due to globalization, technological advancement, and changing tourist preferences. Consequently, tourism destinations are no longer evaluated solely based on their natural attractions but also on the quality of services, accessibility, safety and security, pricing, infrastructure, and the overall travel experience they offer. These destination attributes significantly influence tourists' evaluations of a destination and ultimately determine their level of satisfaction and future behavioral intentions, such as revisiting the destination or recommending it to others (Chen and Tsai, 2007; Chi and Qu, 2008; Yoon and Uysal, 2005).

Tourist satisfaction has emerged as one of the most widely studied constructs in tourism and hospitality literature because it reflects tourists' overall evaluation of their travel experiences. According to Expectation–Confirmation Theory, satisfaction is formed when tourists perceive that their actual travel experiences meet or exceed their prior expectations. Satisfied tourists are more likely to revisit a destination, recommend it to friends and relatives, and develop long-term loyalty toward the destination (Oliver, 1980; Prayag et al., 2017). Consequently, tourist satisfaction is widely regarded as a critical determinant of destination competitiveness and sustainable tourism development.

Behavioral intentions represent tourists' future responses after experiencing a destination and are commonly measured through revisit intention, recommendation intention, and positive word-of-mouth communication. These behavioral outcomes are particularly important because acquiring new tourists is generally more expensive than retaining existing visitors. Therefore, understanding the determinants of tourists' behavioral intentions has become a major concern for destination managers, tourism entrepreneurs, and policymakers seeking to strengthen destination competitiveness and ensure long-term tourism sustainability (Stylos et al., 2016; Rasoolimanesh et al., 2022).

Previous empirical studies have consistently reported that destination attributes such as destination attractiveness, service quality, accessibility, safety and security, and price perception significantly influence tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions. However, the magnitude and direction of these relationships vary across destinations due to differences in geographical characteristics, tourism infrastructure, cultural environments, and visitor expectations. These variations indicate that empirical findings from one destination may not be directly applicable to another, highlighting the importance of conducting destination-specific studies (Žabkar et al., 2010; Eusébio and Vieira, 2013).

Nepal possesses exceptional tourism resources, including the Himalayas, UNESCO World Heritage Sites, rich cultural diversity, religious pilgrimage destinations, wildlife reserves, and adventure tourism opportunities. Tourism plays a significant role in Nepal's economy by generating foreign exchange earnings, creating employment opportunities, supporting local businesses, and promoting regional development. According to the Nepal Tourism Board, international tourist arrivals have shown steady recovery following the COVID-19 pandemic, indicating renewed global interest in Nepal as a tourism destination (Nepal Tourism Board, 2025). Similarly, the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation recognizes tourism as one of the country's priority sectors for achieving sustainable economic growth and improving international competitiveness (Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, 2024). International organizations, including UN Tourism, the World Bank, and the Asian Development Bank, have also emphasized the importance of improving tourism infrastructure, destination management, service quality, accessibility, and sustainability to strengthen Nepal's tourism sector (UN Tourism, 2024b; World Bank, 2024b; Asian Development Bank, 2024a).

Despite Nepal's considerable tourism potential, several challenges continue to affect the quality of tourists' experiences. Issues related to transportation infrastructure, accessibility, sanitation, service quality, destination management, environmental conservation, safety, and information availability may influence tourists' satisfaction and their willingness to revisit Nepal or recommend it to others. Although several studies have investigated tourist satisfaction, destination image, or service quality in Nepal, comprehensive research examining the integrated relationships among destination attributes, tourist satisfaction,

and behavioral intentions remains limited. Furthermore, relatively few studies have employed Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) to examine both the direct and indirect relationships among these constructs while accounting for tourist characteristics and travel characteristics as control variables.

Against this background, the present literature review critically examines the theoretical foundations, conceptual perspectives, and empirical evidence related to destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions. The review first discusses the major theories underpinning tourist behavior and destination evaluation, followed by a conceptual discussion of the principal study variables. Subsequently, it synthesizes findings from international and Nepalese empirical studies to identify existing knowledge, methodological approaches, and research gaps. Finally, the chapter develops the conceptual framework and research hypotheses that guide the empirical investigation of this study.

7.2 Theoretical Foundations

The present study is grounded in several well-established theories in tourism, consumer behavior, and hospitality management. These theories provide the conceptual basis for explaining how destination attributes influence tourist satisfaction and how satisfied tourists develop favorable behavioral intentions, such as revisit intention and recommendation intention. Specifically, the study draws upon the Expectation–Confirmation Theory (ECT), the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), the Stimulus–Organism–Response (SOR) Theory, Destination Competitiveness Theory, and the SERVQUAL model. Together, these theories provide a comprehensive framework for understanding tourists’ evaluation processes and post-visit behavioral responses.

7.2.1 Expectation–Confirmation Theory (ECT)

Expectation–Confirmation Theory (ECT), originally proposed by Oliver (1980), is one of the most widely used theories for explaining customer satisfaction and post-purchase behavior. The theory suggests that consumers develop expectations before purchasing a product or service. After experiencing the product or service, they compare the actual performance with their initial expectations. If the perceived performance meets or exceeds expectations, positive confirmation occurs, resulting in customer satisfaction. Conversely, if performance falls below expectations, negative confirmation leads to dissatisfaction.

In tourism, visitors establish expectations about a destination before travel through promotional materials, social media, previous experiences, and recommendations from others. During the visit, tourists evaluate various destination attributes, including destination attractiveness, service quality, accessibility, safety and security, and price fairness. These evaluations determine the extent to which expectations are confirmed, ultimately influencing overall tourist satisfaction.

Numerous tourism studies have confirmed that destination attributes significantly influence tourist satisfaction through the expectation-confirmation process (Chen and Tsai, 2007; Chi and Qu, 2008; Prayag, 2009). Tourist satisfaction subsequently affects revisit intention, destination loyalty, and recommendation intention. Therefore, Expectation–Confirmation Theory provides the primary theoretical foundation for examining the mediating role of tourist satisfaction in the present study.

Within this research, destination attributes represent tourists' perceived destination performance, while tourist satisfaction reflects the confirmation of pre-travel expectations. Consequently, ECT provides theoretical justification for the proposed relationships between destination attributes and tourist satisfaction.

7.2.2 Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB)

The Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), developed by ?, explains how individuals' intentions determine their future behavior. According to the theory, behavioral intention is influenced by three components: attitude toward the behavior, subjective norms, and perceived behavioral control.

In tourism research, TPB has been extensively used to explain tourists' intentions to revisit destinations, recommend destinations to others, and engage in positive word-of-mouth communication. Tourists who develop favorable attitudes toward a destination after experiencing satisfactory services are more likely to revisit the destination and recommend it to family members, friends, and colleagues.

Several empirical studies have demonstrated that tourist satisfaction positively influences behavioral intentions, including revisit intention and recommendation intention (Stylos et al., 2016; Prayag et al., 2017; Rasoolimanesh et al., 2022). Therefore, TPB provides theoretical support for the relationship between tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions proposed in this study.

Accordingly, the present study considers behavioral intentions as the outcome variable represented by revisit intention and recommendation intention among international tourists visiting Nepal.

7.2.3 Stimulus–Organism–Response (SOR) Theory

The Stimulus–Organism–Response (SOR) Theory, introduced by ?, explains how environmental stimuli influence individuals' internal psychological states, which subsequently determine behavioral responses. According to the SOR framework, external environmental factors (stimuli) affect internal cognitive and emotional evaluations (organism), which in turn generate behavioral outcomes (response).

In tourism and hospitality research, destination attributes are considered external stimuli that tourists experience during their visit. Tourist satisfaction represents the internal psychological evaluation of these experiences, while behavioral intentions, including revisit intention and recommendation intention, constitute the behavioral responses.

The SOR framework has been widely applied in tourism studies to explain tourists' decision-making processes and post-visit behaviors (Rasoolimanesh et al., 2022; Jeong and Kim, 2021). The theory provides a comprehensive explanation of how destination characteristics influence tourist satisfaction and ultimately shape tourists' future behavioral intentions.

The conceptual framework of the present study closely follows the SOR model, where destination attributes function as stimuli, tourist satisfaction represents the organism, and behavioral intentions constitute the response.

7.2.4 Destination Competitiveness Theory

Destination Competitiveness Theory, proposed by ?, explains the factors that enable tourism destinations to achieve sustainable competitive advantages in the global tourism market. According to the theory, destination competitiveness depends on both inherited resources, such as natural attractions and cultural heritage, and created resources, including tourism infrastructure, service quality, accessibility, destination management, and supporting facilities.

A competitive destination is capable of attracting tourists, providing satisfying experiences, and encouraging repeat visitation. Destination competitiveness is therefore closely associated with tourist satisfaction and destination loyalty.

Nepal possesses numerous inherited tourism resources, including the Himalayas, national parks, cultural heritage sites, religious destinations, and diverse ethnic cultures. However, sustaining competitiveness also requires improvements in destination accessibility, service quality, safety, transportation infrastructure, and tourism management (Nepal Tourism Board, 2025; Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, 2024).

The present study adopts Destination Competitiveness Theory to justify the inclusion of destination attractiveness, accessibility, service quality, price perception, and safety and security as the principal destination attributes influencing tourist satisfaction.

7.2.5 SERVQUAL Theory

SERVQUAL, developed by Parasuraman et al. (1988), is one of the most influential models for measuring perceived service quality. The model proposes that customers evaluate service quality by comparing expected service with perceived service performance across five dimensions: tangibility, reliability, responsiveness, assurance, and empathy.

In tourism and hospitality industries, service quality is considered one of the most important determinants of tourist satisfaction because tourism products are predominantly service-oriented. High-quality accommodation, transportation, hospitality services, tour operations, and visitor information enhance tourists' overall travel experiences and contribute to higher levels of satisfaction.

Numerous empirical studies have demonstrated that service quality positively influences tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions (Chi and Qu, 2008; Zabkar et al., 2010). Consequently, SERVQUAL provides theoretical support for including service quality as one of the destination attributes examined in the present study.

Although the current research does not measure the five SERVQUAL dimensions separately, the overall concept of perceived service quality provides an important theoretical basis for explaining tourists' evaluations of tourism services in Nepal.

7.2.6 Summary of Theoretical Foundations

The five theories discussed above collectively provide the theoretical foundation for the proposed conceptual framework. Expectation–Confirmation Theory explains how destination attributes influence tourist satisfaction through the confirmation of expectations. The Theory of Planned Behavior explains how tourist satisfaction influences future behavioral intentions. The Stimulus–Organism–Response framework integrates these

relationships by conceptualizing destination attributes as stimuli, tourist satisfaction as the organism, and behavioral intentions as the response. Destination Competitiveness Theory provides the rationale for selecting destination attributes as the principal independent variables, while SERVQUAL Theory supports the inclusion of service quality as a critical determinant of tourist satisfaction. Together, these theories establish a comprehensive theoretical basis for examining the behavioral intentions of international tourists visiting Nepal.

7.3 Empirical Review

Empirical studies on tourist behavior have consistently demonstrated that destination attributes play a significant role in shaping tourists' satisfaction and subsequent behavioral intentions. Researchers have examined various destination attributes, including destination attractiveness, service quality, accessibility, safety and security, and price perception, using different methodological approaches and across diverse tourism contexts. Although considerable international evidence exists, empirical research within the Nepalese tourism context remains relatively limited. This section reviews the major empirical findings relevant to the present study.

7.3.1 Destination Attributes and Tourist Satisfaction

Destination attributes represent the physical, environmental, cultural, and service-related characteristics that tourists experience during their visit. Numerous empirical studies have concluded that tourists' evaluations of destination attributes significantly determine their overall satisfaction.

Chen and Tsai (2007) investigated tourists visiting Taiwan using Structural Equation Modeling and reported that destination image and destination attributes significantly influenced tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions. Their findings demonstrated that favorable perceptions of destination quality increased tourists' willingness to revisit the destination and recommend it to others.

Similarly, Chi and Qu (2008) developed a destination loyalty model using SEM and found that destination image positively influenced tourist satisfaction, which subsequently enhanced destination loyalty. Their study highlighted tourist satisfaction as an important mediating construct between destination evaluation and future behavioral responses.

Žabkar et al. (2010) examined tourists visiting Slovenia and reported that destination quality significantly affected tourist satisfaction and destination loyalty. Their study emphasized that tourists evaluate destinations not only based on natural attractions but also on the quality of tourism services and supporting facilities.

Eusébio and Vieira (2013) investigated tourism destinations in Portugal and found that destination attractiveness and destination quality positively affected tourist satisfaction. The study further concluded that satisfied tourists were more likely to recommend the destination to others.

More recently, Rasoolimanesh et al. (2022) employed Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM) and confirmed that destination attributes significantly influenced tourist satisfaction, which subsequently mediated the relationship between

destination characteristics and behavioral intentions. These findings suggest that destination attributes constitute the primary determinants of tourists' post-visit evaluations.

7.3.2 Service Quality and Tourist Satisfaction

Service quality has consistently been recognized as one of the strongest determinants of tourist satisfaction in tourism and hospitality research.

Parasuraman et al. (1988) proposed the SERVQUAL model, which has subsequently been applied extensively in tourism studies to evaluate perceived service quality. Building upon this framework, Chi and Qu (2008) demonstrated that higher perceived service quality significantly improved tourist satisfaction and destination loyalty.

Prayag (2009) reported that tourists' perceptions of accommodation, transportation, hospitality services, and destination management significantly influenced overall satisfaction. Similarly, Stylos et al. (2016) concluded that service quality positively affected tourists' emotional experiences and revisit intentions.

Recent studies using SEM have consistently reported that improvements in tourism service quality enhance tourists' satisfaction and strengthen destination competitiveness. These findings indicate that service quality remains one of the most influential destination attributes affecting tourist behavior.

7.3.3 Price Perception and Tourist Satisfaction

Price perception refers to tourists' evaluation of whether the costs incurred during travel are reasonable relative to the quality of services received.

Several empirical studies have found that perceived price fairness positively influences tourist satisfaction. Chen and Tsai (2007) reported that tourists who perceived destinations as offering good value for money expressed higher satisfaction levels.

Žabkar et al. (2010) similarly concluded that tourists' perceptions of fair pricing significantly enhanced destination satisfaction and destination loyalty. More recently, Rasoolimanesh et al. (2022) demonstrated that perceived value positively influenced tourists' overall evaluations of destinations and their future behavioral intentions.

These findings suggest that pricing strategies should be carefully managed to maintain destination competitiveness and improve tourists' overall experiences.

7.3.4 Accessibility and Tourist Satisfaction

Accessibility is another important determinant of destination competitiveness and tourist satisfaction. It encompasses transportation infrastructure, road conditions, airport facilities, destination connectivity, and ease of movement within destinations.

Studies conducted by Ritchie and Crouch (2003) emphasized that accessibility constitutes one of the fundamental components of destination competitiveness. International organizations, including the World Bank (2024) and the Asian Development Bank (2024), have similarly highlighted transportation infrastructure and accessibility as critical challenges affecting tourism development in developing countries, including Nepal.

Empirical evidence indicates that tourists who experience convenient transportation systems and efficient tourism infrastructure report higher levels of satisfaction and stronger intentions to revisit destinations.

7.3.5 Safety and Security

Safety and security have become increasingly important determinants of tourist satisfaction, particularly following the COVID-19 pandemic.

Jeong et al. (2021) found that tourists' perceptions of health safety, destination cleanliness, and emergency preparedness significantly influenced destination satisfaction and travel intentions.

Similarly, Stylos et al. (2016) concluded that destination safety positively affected tourists' emotional evaluations and behavioral intentions. Rasoolimanesh et al. (2022) further demonstrated that tourists who perceived destinations as safe expressed higher satisfaction and stronger loyalty intentions.

These findings indicate that destination safety contributes significantly to positive travel experiences and sustainable tourism development.

7.3.6 Tourist Satisfaction and Behavioral Intentions

Tourist satisfaction has consistently been identified as one of the strongest predictors of behavioral intentions.

Yoon and Uysal (2005) reported that satisfied tourists demonstrated stronger intentions to revisit destinations and recommend them to others. Their findings supported the proposition that tourist satisfaction serves as an important determinant of destination loyalty.

Chi and Qu (2008) similarly found that tourist satisfaction significantly enhanced destination loyalty through revisit intention and positive word-of-mouth communication.

Prayag et al. (2017) confirmed that tourist satisfaction positively influenced revisit intention, recommendation intention, and destination attachment. More recently, Stylos et al. (2016) and Rasoolimanesh et al. (2022) also reported strong positive relationships between tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions using Structural Equation Modeling.

Collectively, these studies suggest that tourist satisfaction functions as a key psychological mechanism through which destination experiences are translated into future travel behavior.

7.3.7 Empirical Studies in Nepal

Empirical research on international tourists in Nepal has increased over the past decade; however, the literature remains fragmented. Existing studies have primarily focused on destination image, service quality, trekking experiences, tourist satisfaction, and revisit intentions.

Baniya and Paudel (2017) examined the push and pull motivations of international tourists visiting Nepal and reported that natural beauty, cultural heritage, and adventure tourism were major attractions influencing destination choice.

Bam and Kunwar (2020) investigated tourist satisfaction in Nepal and found that service quality, hospitality, and destination experiences significantly influenced tourists' overall evaluations. However, the study employed descriptive statistical techniques and did not examine structural relationships among latent constructs.

Recent studies by Thapa et al. (2025) and Bhattarai et al. (2025) further emphasized the importance of service quality, destination management, and tourist experiences in determining visitor satisfaction. Nevertheless, these studies primarily focused on specific destinations and did not investigate the mediating role of tourist satisfaction using Structural Equation Modeling.

Government reports published by the Nepal Tourism Board (2025) and the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation (2024) indicate that Nepal continues to attract increasing numbers of international tourists. Despite this growth, challenges related to transportation infrastructure, accessibility, destination management, sanitation, and tourism service quality remain important concerns affecting visitor experiences.

Overall, Nepalese tourism studies provide valuable descriptive evidence but offer limited empirical examination of the integrated relationships among destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions. Moreover, the application of Structural Equation Modeling to examine these relationships remains relatively scarce.

7.3.8 Summary of Empirical Review

The empirical literature consistently demonstrates that destination attributes significantly influence tourist satisfaction, which subsequently determines tourists' behavioral intentions. International studies have widely applied Structural Equation Modeling to examine these relationships and have generally confirmed the mediating role of tourist satisfaction. However, empirical evidence from Nepal remains limited, particularly regarding the simultaneous examination of destination attractiveness, service quality, price perception, accessibility, and safety and security within a single integrated framework. Furthermore, few Nepalese studies have incorporated tourist characteristics and travel characteristics as control variables while investigating behavioral intentions. These gaps provide the empirical justification for the present study.

7.4 Research Gap

A review of the existing literature reveals that considerable progress has been made in understanding the relationships among destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions in tourism research. Numerous international studies have confirmed that destination attractiveness, service quality, accessibility, price perception, and safety and security significantly influence tourist satisfaction, which subsequently affects revisit intention, recommendation intention, and destination loyalty (Chen and Tsai, 2007; Chi and Qu, 2008; Žabkar et al., 2010; Stylos et al., 2016; Rasoolimanesh et al., 2022). Despite these contributions, several theoretical, empirical, methodological, contextual, and practical gaps remain, particularly in the context of Nepal.

First, from a theoretical perspective, previous studies have generally focused on individual theoretical frameworks such as Expectation–Confirmation Theory (ECT), the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), or the Stimulus–Organism–Response (SOR) framework

independently. Few studies have integrated these complementary theories into a comprehensive framework to explain how destination attributes influence tourists' behavioral intentions through the mediating role of tourist satisfaction. The present study addresses this limitation by integrating ECT, TPB, SOR Theory, Destination Competitiveness Theory, and SERVQUAL Theory into a unified conceptual model.

Second, an empirical gap exists regarding the selection of destination attributes. Earlier studies have frequently examined only one or two destination characteristics, such as destination image, service quality, or perceived value, without considering the combined influence of destination attractiveness, service quality, price perception, accessibility, and safety and security within a single analytical framework (Chen and Tsai, 2007; Prayag, 2009; Eusébio and Vieira, 2013). Since tourists evaluate destinations based on multiple dimensions simultaneously, an integrated assessment is necessary to obtain a more comprehensive understanding of tourist behavior.

Third, methodological limitations are evident in the existing literature. Many previous studies have relied on descriptive statistics, correlation analysis, or multiple regression techniques, which do not adequately capture the complex relationships among latent variables. Although Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) has increasingly been applied in international tourism research, its application in Nepal remains relatively limited (Hair et al., 2022; Kline, 2023). Furthermore, relatively few studies have simultaneously examined both direct and indirect effects through mediation analysis. This study addresses this methodological gap by employing SEM to examine the structural relationships among destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions.

Fourth, a contextual gap exists because most empirical evidence has been generated from developed tourism destinations in Europe, North America, East Asia, and Oceania. Differences in tourism infrastructure, cultural environments, destination management practices, and visitor expectations limit the generalizability of these findings to developing countries such as Nepal. Although Nepal is internationally recognized for its natural beauty, cultural diversity, religious heritage, and adventure tourism, empirical evidence examining international tourists' behavioral intentions remains limited (Nepal Tourism Board, 2025; Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, 2024). Consequently, destination-specific research is required to better understand the determinants of tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions within the Nepalese context.

Fifth, existing Nepalese studies have primarily focused on specific aspects of tourism, including tourist motivation, destination image, hotel service quality, trekking experiences, or visitor satisfaction, often in particular destinations or regions (Baniya et al., 2017; Bam and Kunwar, 2020; Bhattarai et al., 2025). Very few studies have simultaneously examined multiple destination attributes and their influence on tourists' behavioral intentions through the mediating role of tourist satisfaction. Moreover, the majority of Nepalese studies have concentrated on domestic tourists or visitors to individual destinations, providing limited evidence regarding international tourists visiting Nepal as a whole.

Sixth, previous studies have paid relatively little attention to the potential influence of tourist characteristics and travel characteristics. Variables such as age, gender, nationality, education, income, purpose of visit, length of stay, accommodation type, and travel companion may influence tourists' perceptions and post-visit behaviors. However, these variables have seldom been incorporated as control variables in empirical tourism studies

conducted in Nepal. Including these control variables will improve the robustness of the proposed structural model and provide more reliable estimates of the relationships among the principal constructs.

Finally, from a practical perspective, Nepal's tourism sector continues to face challenges related to transportation infrastructure, accessibility, destination management, service quality, environmental sustainability, and visitor safety (World Bank, 2024b; Asian Development Bank, 2024a). While government agencies and tourism stakeholders have implemented various tourism development initiatives, there remains limited empirical evidence identifying which destination attributes most strongly influence international tourists' satisfaction and future behavioral intentions. The findings of this study are therefore expected to provide evidence-based recommendations for policymakers, the Nepal Tourism Board, the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, destination management organizations, hotel operators, travel agencies, and other tourism stakeholders.

In summary, the present study seeks to address these theoretical, empirical, methodological, contextual, and practical gaps by developing and empirically testing an integrated Structural Equation Model that examines the influence of destination attractiveness, service quality, price perception, accessibility, and safety and security on the behavioral intentions of international tourists through the mediating role of tourist satisfaction while controlling for tourist characteristics and travel characteristics. The study is expected to contribute to both tourism theory and tourism management by providing comprehensive empirical evidence from the Nepalese tourism context.

Table 1: Summary of Research Gaps

Gap Type	Existing Literature	Present Study
Theoretical Gap	Theories applied separately	Integrates ECT, TPB, SOR, Destination Competitiveness Theory, and SERVQUAL into one framework.
Empirical Gap	Focus on limited destination attributes	Examines destination attractiveness, service quality, price perception, accessibility, and safety & security simultaneously.
Methodological Gap	Predominantly descriptive statistics and regression	Applies Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) to test direct and indirect relationships.
Contextual Gap	Evidence concentrated in developed tourism destinations	Provides empirical evidence from Nepal, a developing tourism destination.
Control Variable Gap	Limited consideration of tourist and travel characteristics	Includes tourist characteristics and travel characteristics as control variables.
Practical Gap	Limited evidence for tourism policy and destination management	Generates evidence to support destination planning, marketing, and service improvement in Nepal.

Table 2: Summary of Empirical Literature

Author(s)	Country	Method	Key Finding	Gap Relative to This Study
Chen & Tsai (2007)	Taiwan	SEM	Destination image positively influences perceived value, tourist satisfaction, and behavioral intentions.	Did not examine accessibility, safety and security, or tourist/travel characteristics as control variables.
Žabkar, Brenčič & Dmitrović (2010)	Slovenia	SEM	Perceived destination quality significantly improves visitor satisfaction and destination loyalty.	Focused on destination quality; omitted accessibility, price perception and control variables.
Eusébio & Vieira (2013)	Portugal	SEM	Destination attributes positively affect tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions.	Focused on coastal destinations and did not investigate international tourists in Nepal.
Qiu et al. (2018)	China	SEM	Self-drive destination attributes significantly influence tourist satisfaction and loyalty.	Restricted to self-drive tourism; findings may not generalize to international tourists.
Silva et al. (2016)	Portugal	SEM	Destination attributes are important determinants of tourists' behavioral intentions.	Did not assess the mediating role of tourist satisfaction comprehensively.
Yoon & Uysal (2005)	USA	SEM	Travel motivation positively influences tourist satisfaction and destination loyalty.	Focused on motivation rather than destination attributes.
Chi & Qu (2008)	USA	SEM	Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between destination image and destination loyalty.	Destination image received greater emphasis than multidimensional destination attributes.
Prayag (2009)	Mauritius	SEM	Destination image significantly influences tourist satisfaction and future behavioral intentions.	Did not simultaneously examine accessibility, safety and perceived price.
Assaker et al. (2011)	Australia	SEM	Novelty seeking and destination image influence satisfaction and loyalty intentions.	Limited consideration of destination service attributes.
Alananzeh et al. (2018)	Jordan	SEM	Safety, service quality and destination image significantly influence tourist satisfaction.	Focused on Middle Eastern destinations; omitted accessibility and travel characteristics.
Rasoolimanesh et al. (2022)	Malaysia	PLS-SEM	Visitor satisfaction significantly mediates the relationship between destination attributes and behavioral intentions.	Focused on a heritage destination; findings need validation for international tourists in Nepal.
Bam & Kunwar (2020)	Nepal	SEM	Tourist satisfaction significantly influences revisit intention and recommendation intention.	Examined limited antecedents of satisfaction; destination attributes were not comprehensively incorporated.
Prayag et al. (2017)	Mauritius	SEM	Tourists' emotional experiences positively influence satisfaction, attachment, and loyalty.	Emphasized emotional attachment rather than multidimensional destination attributes.
Rasoolimanesh et al. (2016)	Malaysia	PLS-SEM	Perceived value positively influences tourist satisfaction and loyalty in community-based tourism.	Focused on community-based tourism rather than national tourism destinations.
Kim, Ritchie & McCormick (2012)	South Korea	Scale Development (SEM)	Developed and validated the Memorable Tourism Experience (MTE) scale as a predictor of future behavioral intentions.	Focused on memorable experiences rather than destination attributes.

Continued on next page

Table 2 – Continued from previous page

Author(s)	Country	Method	Key Finding	Gap Relative to This Study
Stylos et al. (2016)	Greece	SEM	Destination image and personal normative beliefs significantly influence destination choice and revisit intention.	Did not explicitly examine tourist satisfaction as a mediating construct.
Rather (2021)	India	SEM	Customer experience and engagement significantly improve tourist satisfaction and destination loyalty.	Focused primarily on customer engagement rather than destination characteristics.
Gohary et al. (2020)	Iran	SEM	Memorable tourism experiences positively influence tourist satisfaction and revisit intention.	Did not evaluate accessibility, safety, or price perception.
Lee, Lee & Choi (2011)	South Korea	SEM	Physical environment, food quality, and service quality significantly influence tourist satisfaction and loyalty.	Focused on festival tourism rather than overall destination evaluation.
Moon & Han (2019)	South Korea	PLS-SEM	Destination attributes significantly affect tourist satisfaction and environmentally responsible behavioral intentions.	Concentrated on eco-tourism; findings may not generalize to Nepal's diverse tourism destinations.
Marques et al. (2021)	Portugal	SEM	Destination image positively influences tourist satisfaction and loyalty through tourists' experiences.	Focused on European destinations; findings require validation for Nepal's tourism context.
Jeong et al. (2021)	South Korea	SEM	Perceived health safety during the COVID-19 pandemic significantly affects travel intentions.	Examined pandemic-related travel behaviour rather than overall destination attributes.
Hasan et al. (2023)	Bangladesh	PLS-SEM	Coastal destination attributes significantly influence tourist satisfaction and revisit intention.	Restricted to coastal tourism; findings may not generalize to mountain destinations such as Nepal.
Anabila et al. (2023)	Ghana	SEM	Destination marketing and visitor experiences positively affect destination loyalty.	Greater emphasis on marketing than comprehensive destination attributes.
Liao et al. (2021)	China	SEM	Destination image enhances tourist satisfaction through perceived value.	Accessibility and travel characteristics were not incorporated.
Atmari et al. (2021)	Indonesia	PLS-SEM	Tourism experience and service quality significantly improve tourist satisfaction and revisit intention.	Focused mainly on tourism experience rather than multidimensional destination attributes.
Viana et al. (2021)	Portugal	SEM	Destination quality positively influences tourists' behavioural intentions through satisfaction.	Did not examine tourist demographic and travel characteristics as control variables.
Olivar et al. (2021)	Spain	SEM	Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between destination image and loyalty intentions.	Focused on Mediterranean tourism destinations only.
Ali et al. (2016)	Malaysia	SEM	Creative tourism experiences significantly enhance tourist satisfaction and loyalty.	Focused on creative tourism rather than general destination attributes.
Rasoolimanesh et al. (2018)	Malaysia	PLS-SEM Methodological Application	Demonstrated the usefulness of PLS-SEM for modelling complex tourism relationships involving latent constructs.	Methodological contribution; did not investigate international tourists visiting Nepal.

Continued on next page

Table 2 – Continued from previous page

Author(s)	Country	Method	Key Finding	Gap Relative to This Study
Bam & Kunwar (2020)	Nepal	SEM	Tourist satisfaction significantly influences revisit intention and recommendation intention among visitors to Pokhara.	Focused mainly on satisfaction antecedents; destination attributes were not comprehensively examined.
Baniya (2017)	Nepal	Questionnaire Survey	Push and pull factors significantly influence international tourists' travel decisions to Nepal.	Did not investigate tourist satisfaction or behavioral intentions using SEM.
Sapkota (2025a)	Nepal	SEM	Destination attributes significantly influence tourist satisfaction and revisit intention in Pokhara.	Limited geographical coverage; recommendation intention was not simultaneously examined.
Sapkota (2025b)	Nepal	SEM	Intangible destination factors contribute significantly to tourists' overall experience and satisfaction.	Focused on Gandaki Province; omitted travel characteristics as control variables.
Thapa, Bajracharya & Poudel (2025)	Nepal	PLS-SEM	Service quality and tourist experience significantly enhance revisit and recommendation intentions through satisfaction.	Focused primarily on service quality; destination attractiveness and accessibility were not comprehensively incorporated.
Bhattarai et al. (2025)	Nepal	SEM	Service quality positively affects tourist satisfaction and subsequent behavioral intentions.	Did not include destination safety, accessibility, and price perception in the structural model.
Bhatt (2025)	Nepal	SEM	Tourists' trustworthiness perceptions significantly improve satisfaction and destination loyalty.	Examined trust as the main predictor; broader destination attributes were not evaluated.
Nepal Tourism Board (2024)	Nepal	Statistical Report	International tourist arrivals continue to recover, with increasing contributions from leisure and adventure tourism.	Descriptive report; no empirical analysis of tourist satisfaction or behavioral intentions.
Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation (2024)	Nepal	Government Report	Highlights tourism policies, infrastructure development, and visitor trends in Nepal.	Policy-oriented report without statistical modelling of tourist behavior.
World Bank (2024)	Nepal	Development Report	Tourism recovery is important for Nepal's economic growth and employment generation.	Macroeconomic perspective only; individual tourist satisfaction and behavioral intentions were not examined.

8 Hypothesis Development

8.1 Destination Attractiveness and Tourist Satisfaction

Destination attractiveness refers to the extent to which a destination possesses natural, cultural, historical, and recreational resources that motivate tourists to visit and influence their overall travel experience. Attractive destinations provide memorable experiences through scenic beauty, cultural heritage, entertainment opportunities, and unique local attractions, thereby enhancing tourists' perceptions of value and enjoyment. According to destination image and consumer behavior theories, tourists who perceive a destination as attractive are more likely to evaluate their travel experience positively and report higher levels of satisfaction.

Empirical evidence consistently supports this relationship. Chen and Tsai (2007) demonstrated that destination image significantly influences tourist satisfaction and subsequent behavioral intentions. Similarly, Eusébio and Vieira (2013) and Qiu et al. (2018) found that attractive destination characteristics enhance tourists' satisfaction and loyalty. More recently, ? reported that destination attractiveness is a significant determinant of tourist satisfaction in the Nepalese tourism context.

Accordingly, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H₁: Destination attractiveness has a positive and significant effect on tourist satisfaction.

8.2 Service Quality and Tourist Satisfaction

Service quality represents tourists' overall evaluation of the quality of services received during their travel experience, including accommodation, transportation, restaurants, tour guiding, and interactions with local residents. Expectation Confirmation Theory suggests that tourists compare perceived service performance with their prior expectations. When perceived service quality exceeds expectations, tourists experience higher levels of satisfaction.

Previous studies consistently demonstrate a positive association between service quality and tourist satisfaction. Cronin et al. (2000) concluded that superior service quality significantly enhances customer satisfaction and behavioral intentions. Likewise, Chen and Chen (2010) and ? reported that service quality positively affects tourists' satisfaction across various tourism destinations. Similar findings have also been reported by ? in the Nepalese tourism industry.

Therefore, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H₂: Service quality has a positive and significant effect on tourist satisfaction.

8.3 Price Perception and Tourist Satisfaction

Price perception refers to tourists' evaluation of whether the benefits obtained from tourism products and services justify the costs incurred during their trip. Rather than focusing solely on the absolute price, tourists evaluate value for money by comparing service quality

with the expenses associated with accommodation, transportation, food, entrance fees, and other travel-related expenditures.

When tourists perceive prices as fair and consistent with the quality of services received, they are more likely to experience higher satisfaction. Chen and Tsai (2007) reported that perceived value significantly contributes to tourist satisfaction and future behavioral intentions. Similarly, Rasoolimanesh et al. (2022) found that perceived value positively influences tourists' satisfaction and destination loyalty.

Hence, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H₃: Price perception has a positive and significant effect on tourist satisfaction.

8.4 Accessibility and Tourist Satisfaction

Accessibility refers to the ease with which tourists can reach a destination and move conveniently within it. It includes transportation infrastructure, road conditions, availability of public transportation, directional signage, digital information, and connectivity among tourism attractions. Better accessibility minimizes travel inconvenience, reduces travel time, and enhances the overall tourism experience.

Several studies have identified accessibility as an important determinant of tourist satisfaction. For example, Eusébio and Vieira (2013) reported that transportation facilities significantly improve tourists' overall evaluations of destinations. Likewise, Silva et al. (2016) and ? concluded that better accessibility contributes positively to tourist satisfaction.

Accordingly, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H₄: Accessibility has a positive and significant effect on tourist satisfaction.

8.5 Safety and Security and Tourist Satisfaction

Safety and security constitute fundamental dimensions of destination quality. Tourists generally prefer destinations where they feel physically, socially, financially, and environmentally secure. Perceived safety reduces travel-related anxiety, increases confidence, and contributes to a more enjoyable tourism experience.

Previous empirical studies consistently indicate that safety perceptions significantly influence tourist satisfaction. Alananzeh et al. (2018) found that destination safety positively affects tourists' satisfaction. Furthermore, ? highlighted that health and safety perceptions have become increasingly important determinants of tourist satisfaction in the post-pandemic tourism environment.

Therefore, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H₅: Safety and security have a positive and significant effect on tourist satisfaction.

8.6 Tourist Satisfaction and Revisit Intention

Tourist satisfaction is widely regarded as one of the strongest predictors of revisit intention. According to Expectation Confirmation Theory, satisfied tourists develop favorable attitudes

toward a destination and are more willing to revisit because positive experiences reduce uncertainty associated with future travel decisions.

Numerous empirical studies support this relationship. Chi and Qu (2008), Prayag (2009), Bam and Kunwar (2020), and ? consistently found that tourist satisfaction significantly increases revisit intention.

Accordingly, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H₆: Tourist satisfaction has a positive and significant effect on revisit intention.

8.7 Tourist Satisfaction and Recommendation Intention

Recommendation intention refers to tourists' willingness to recommend a destination to relatives, friends, and colleagues through positive word-of-mouth communication. Satisfied tourists are more likely to share favorable travel experiences, thereby encouraging potential tourists to visit the destination.

Previous studies consistently support this relationship. Chen and Tsai (2007), Chi and Qu (2008), Žabkar et al. (2010), and Bam and Kunwar (2020) concluded that tourist satisfaction positively influences recommendation intention.

Therefore, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H₇: Tourist satisfaction has a positive and significant effect on recommendation intention.

8.8 The Mediating Role of Tourist Satisfaction

Tourist satisfaction is expected to mediate the relationship between destination attributes and tourists' post-visit behavioral intentions. Attractive destinations, high-quality services, reasonable prices, good accessibility, and safe environments create positive travel experiences that enhance tourists' satisfaction. Increased satisfaction subsequently strengthens tourists' intentions to revisit the destination and recommend it to others.

Previous studies have demonstrated the mediating role of tourist satisfaction in tourism behavior. Chen and Tsai (2007), Chi and Qu (2008), Rasoolimanesh et al. (2022), and ? found that tourist satisfaction significantly mediates the effects of destination-related factors on tourists' behavioral intentions.

Accordingly, the following mediation hypotheses are proposed:

- **H_{8a}**: Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between destination attractiveness and revisit intention.
- **H_{8b}**: Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between destination attractiveness and recommendation intention.
- **H_{9a}**: Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between service quality and revisit intention.
- **H_{9b}**: Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between service quality and recommendation intention.

- **H_{10a}**: Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between price perception and revisit intention.
- **H_{10b}**: Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between price perception and recommendation intention.
- **H_{11a}**: Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between accessibility and revisit intention.
- **H_{11b}**: Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between accessibility and recommendation intention.
- **H_{12a}**: Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between safety and security and revisit intention.
- **H_{12b}**: Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationship between safety and security and recommendation intention.

Table 3: Summary of Proposed Hypotheses

Hypothesis	Statement
H ₁	Destination attractiveness → Tourist satisfaction (+)
H ₂	Service quality → Tourist satisfaction (+)
H ₃	Price perception → Tourist satisfaction (+)
H ₄	Accessibility → Tourist satisfaction (+)
H ₅	Safety and security → Tourist satisfaction (+)
H ₆	Tourist satisfaction → Revisit intention (+)
H ₇	Tourist satisfaction → Recommendation intention (+)
H _{8a} –H _{12b}	Tourist satisfaction mediates the relationships between destination attributes and behavioral intentions.

8.9 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework of Destination Attribute, Tourist Satisfaction and Behavioral International Tourist in Nepal.

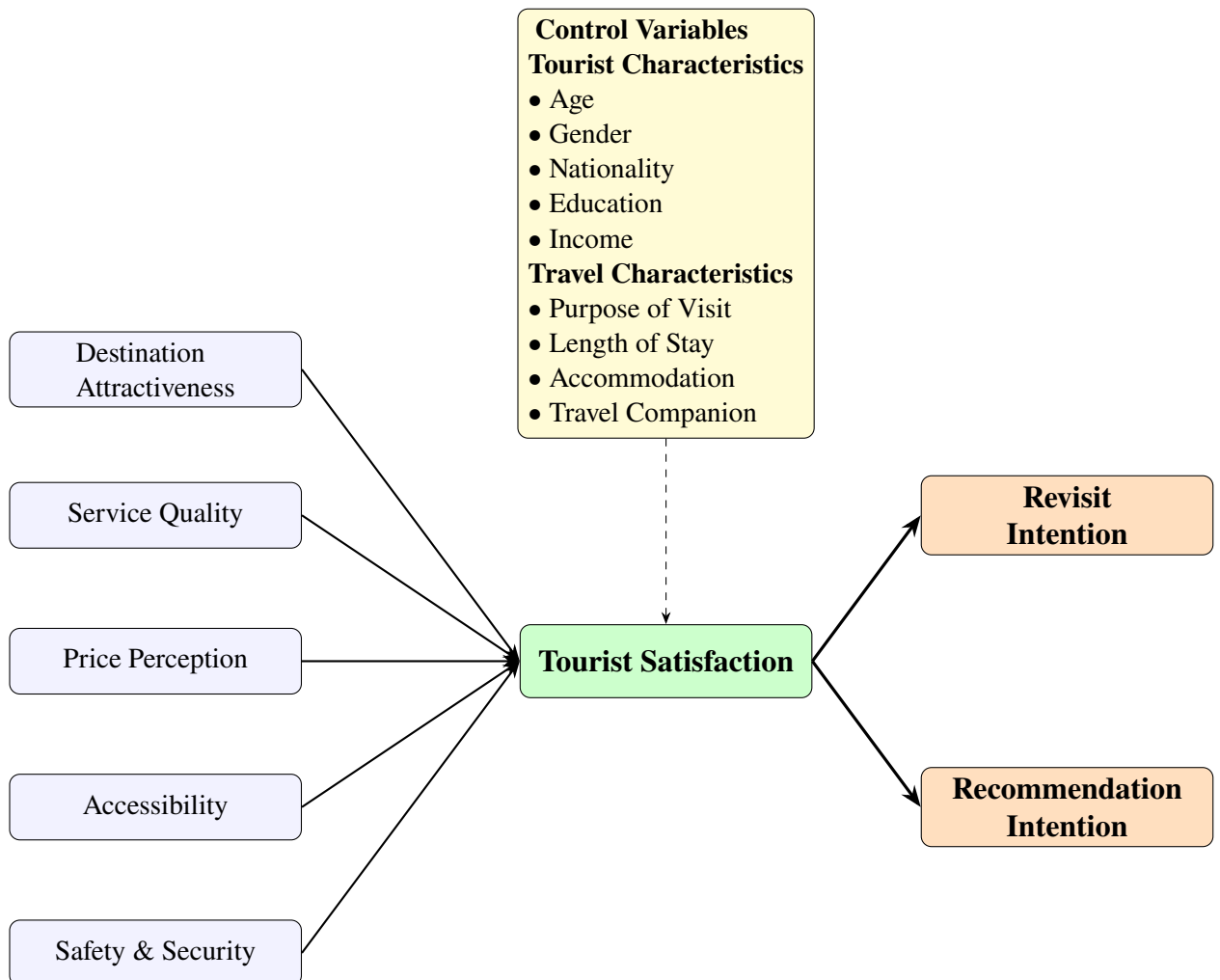


Figure 1: Conceptual Framework

9 Research Methodology

This chapter presents the methodology adopted for examining the relationships among destination attractiveness, service quality, price perception, accessibility, safety and security, tourist satisfaction, revisit intention, and recommendation intention of international tourists visiting Nepal. This chapter describes the research philosophy, research approach, research design, study area, target population, sampling procedure, sample size determination, questionnaire development, measurement of constructs, data collection procedure, reliability and validity assessment, ethical considerations, and the statistical techniques employed to test the proposed hypotheses using Structural Equation Modelling (SEM).

9.1 Research Philosophy

The study adopts the positivist research philosophy because it seeks to test theoretically derived hypotheses using quantitative data collected through a structured questionnaire. Positivism assumes that social phenomena can be measured objectively and analysed using statistical techniques. The present study investigates causal relationships among latent constructs.

9.2 Research Approach

The study follows a deductive approach. Based on the literature reviewed, hypotheses H1–H12b has been developed and will be empirically tested using survey data obtained from international tourists visiting Nepal.

9.3 Research Design

A quantitative, explanatory, cross-sectional survey design will be employed. The explanatory design enables the examination of cause–effect relationships among destination attributes, tourist satisfaction, revisit intention, and recommendation intention.

9.4 Study Area

The study focuses on major tourism destinations of Nepal including Kathmandu Valley, Pokhara, Chitwan, Lumbini and other major tourist destinations where international visitors are concentrated.

9.5 Population and Sampling

The target population comprises international tourists aged 18 years and above visiting Nepal during the study period. Convenience sampling was employed because a complete sampling frame of international tourists was unavailable. Respondents were approached at tourist attractions, hotels, airports and transportation hubs.

9.6 Sample Size

The sample size was determined following recommendations for Structural Equation Modelling. Hair et al. (2022) has recommend that covariance-based SEM generally

requires a sufficiently large sample to obtain stable parameter estimates. Accordingly, a target sample of at least 400 respondents will be considered appropriate.

9.7 Sources of Data

Both primary and secondary data were used. Primary data were collected through a structured questionnaire. Secondary information was obtained from peer-reviewed journal articles, books, Nepal Tourism Board publications and other official reports.

9.8 Questionnaire Design

The questionnaire consisted of two sections. The first section collected demographic and travel-related characteristics. The second section measured destination attractiveness, service quality, price perception, accessibility, safety and security, tourist satisfaction, revisit intention and recommendation intention using five-point Likert-scale items adapted from previous studies.

9.9 Operationalization of Variables

The constructs will be measured using validated scales adapted from previous tourism studies. All items were measured on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

UdayabohorasectionPilot Study Prior to the main survey, the questionnaire was pilot tested to evaluate wording, clarity and internal consistency. Necessary revisions will be incorporated before the full-scale survey.

9.10 Data Collection Procedure

Data will be collected through face-to-face administration of questionnaires to international tourists after obtaining informed consent. Participation will be voluntary and anonymous.

9.11 Data Analysis

R and R studio will be used for data screening, descriptive analysis, Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) and Structural Equation Modelling (SEM). Descriptive statistics summarises respondent characteristics. Reliability will be assessed using Cronbach's alpha and Composite Reliability. Convergent validity will be examined through standardized factor loadings and Average Variance Extracted (AVE). Discriminant validity will be assessed using the Fornell–Larcker criterion and HTMT where applicable. The structural model will be evaluated using standard goodness-of-fit indices including χ^2/df , CFI, TLI, GFI, RMSEA and SRMR. Direct effects will be examined using standardized regression coefficients, whereas mediation hypotheses will be tested using bootstrap confidence intervals.

9.12 Ethical Considerations

Participation will be voluntary. Respondents will be informed about the purpose of the study and assured that the information collected would be used solely for academic

purposes. Confidentiality and anonymity will be maintained throughout the study. The collected information will be used exclusively for academic purposes.

9.13 Chapter Summary

This chapter described the methodology employed in the study, including the research philosophy, design, sampling strategy, questionnaire development, data collection procedures and statistical analyses.

10 Limitations

10.1 Data Limitations

10.2 Limitations of the Structural Equation Model

11 Timeline (Gantt Chart)

The proposed research is expected to be completed over three years (2027–2029). The tentative schedule of research activities is presented in Table 4.

Table 4: Proposed Research Timeline (2027–2029)

Research Activities	2027				2028				2029			
	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4
Coursework, literature review, and proposal finalization												
Sampling frame development and survey instrument design/pilot												
Secondary data compilation and preliminary econometric analysis												
Primary data collection (Firm Survey)												
Component A: ARDL/VECM/Granger Causality Estimation												
Component B: CFA/SEM Estimation and Validation												
Model Integration, Forecasting, and Validation												
Conference Presentation / Journal Publication												
Draft Thesis Writing												
Submission and Finalization of Thesis												

Note: Shaded cells indicate the period during which each research activity will be undertaken.

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QUESTIONNAIRE

Destination Attributes, Tourist Satisfaction, and Behavioral Intentions of International Tourists in Nepal

Dear Respondent

This questionnaire is designed to collect information for an academic research entitled

“Destination Attributes, Tourist Satisfaction, and Behavioral Intentions of International Tourists in Nepal”

being conducted as partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Master of Hospitality Management (MHM).

Your participation is completely voluntary. All information provided by you will be kept strictly confidential and will be used solely for academic purposes.

The questionnaire requires approximately 10–15 minutes to complete.

Thank you very much for your valuable cooperation.

Researcher

Name:

Institution: Nepal Academy of Tourism and Hotel Management (NATHM)

Email:

Telephone:

Instructions

Please tick (✓) the appropriate response.

For Sections C–I, please indicate your opinion using the following scale.

1	2	3	4	5
Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly Agree

Section A: Tourist Characteristics

[label=A0.]

1. Gender

- Male
- Female

- Other
- Prefer not to say

2. Age

- Below 20 years
- 20–29 years
- 30–39 years
- 40–49 years
- 50–59 years
- 60 years and above

3. Nationality

4. Highest Educational Qualification

- High School
- Diploma
- Bachelor's Degree
- Master's Degree
- PhD
- Others

5. Monthly Income (Approx.)

- Below US\$1,000
- US\$1,001–2,000
- US\$2,001–4,000
- US\$4,001–6,000
- Above US\$6,000

Section B: Travel Characteristics

[label=**B0.**]

1. Purpose of Visit

- Holiday
- Trekking
- Pilgrimage
- Adventure

- Business
 - Visiting Friends/Relatives
 - Others
2. Length of Stay
- Less than 5 days
 - 5–10 days
 - 11–15 days
 - 16–20 days
 - More than 20 days
3. Accommodation
- Hotel
 - Resort
 - Guest House
 - Hostel
 - Homestay
 - Others
4. Travel Companion
- Alone
 - Family
 - Friends
 - Organized Tour Group
 - Partner
5. Number of Previous Visits to Nepal
- First Visit
 - Second Visit
 - Third Visit
 - More than Three Visits

Section C: Destination Attributes

Table 5: Questionnaire Development Matrix

Construct	Code	Measurement Item	Adapted From	DOI
Destination Attractiveness	DA1	Nepal has attractive natural scenery.	Chen & Tsai (2007)	10.1016/j.tourman.2006.07.007
	DA2	Nepal has rich cultural and historical attractions.	Beerli & Martín (2004)	10.1016/j.annals.2004.01.010
	DA3	Nepal offers diverse tourism activities.	Chen & Tsai (2007)	10.1016/j.tourman.2006.07.007
	DA4	Nepal provides unique tourism experiences.	Chi & Qu (2008)	10.1016/j.tourman.2007.06.007
	DA5	Overall, Nepal is an attractive tourism destination.	Chen & Tsai (2007)	10.1016/j.tourman.2006.07.007
Service Quality	SQ1	Accommodation services met my expectations.	Cronin et al. (2000)	10.1016/S0022-4359(00)00028-2
	SQ2	Transportation services were satisfactory.	Chen & Chen (2010)	10.1016/j.tourman.2009.02.008
	SQ3	Tourism staff were courteous and helpful.	Cronin et al. (2000)	10.1016/S0022-4359(00)00028-2
	SQ4	Restaurants and food services were satisfactory.	Chen & Chen (2010)	10.1016/j.tourman.2009.02.008
	SQ5	Overall tourism services were of high quality.	Cronin et al. (2000)	10.1016/S0022-4359(00)00028-2
Price Perception	PP1	Tourism services provide good value for money.	Chen & Tsai (2007)	10.1016/j.tourman.2006.07.007
	PP2	Accommodation prices are reasonable.	Zeithaml (1988)	10.2307/1251446
	PP3	Transportation costs are reasonable.	Zeithaml (1988)	10.2307/1251446
	PP4	Food and beverage prices are acceptable.	Chen & Tsai (2007)	10.1016/j.tourman.2006.07.007
	PP5	Overall travel expenses in Nepal are worth the experience.	Zeithaml (1988)	10.2307/1251446

Table 5 Continued

Construct	Code	Measurement Item	Adapted From	DOI
Accessibility	AC1	Tourist destinations in Nepal are easy to reach.	Qiu et al. (2018)	10.1080/10941665.2018.1445117
	AC2	Transportation facilities are convenient for tourists.	Qiu et al. (2018)	10.1080/10941665.2018.1445117
	AC3	Tourist information is easily available.	Eusébio & Vieira (2013)	10.1080/13683500.2013.868412
	AC4	Directional signs and information boards are adequate.	Qiu et al. (2018)	10.1080/10941665.2018.1445117
	AC5	Tourism facilities are easily accessible.	Eusébio & Vieira (2013)	10.1080/13683500.2013.868412
Safety and Security	SS1	I felt safe while travelling in Nepal.	Lu & Atadil (2021)	10.1016/j.tmp.2021.100881
	SS2	Tourist destinations in Nepal are secure.	Lu & Atadil (2021)	10.1016/j.tmp.2021.100881
	SS3	Nepal has a safe environment for international tourists.	Lu & Atadil (2021)	10.1016/j.tmp.2021.100881
	SS4	Emergency services are readily available for tourists in Nepal.	Alanzeh et al. (2018)	10.5539/ass.v14n7p9
	SS5	Overall, Nepal is a safe destination for international tourists.	Lu & Atadil (2021)	10.1016/j.tmp.2021.100881
Tourist Satisfaction	TS1	Overall, I am satisfied with my visit to Nepal.	Chi & Qu (2008)	10.1016/j.tourman.2007.06.007
	TS2	Nepal met my travel expectations.	Chen & Tsai (2007)	10.1016/j.tourman.2006.07.007
	TS3	Choosing Nepal as my destination was a wise decision.	Oliver (1980)	10.2307/3150499
	TS4	My overall tourism experience was enjoyable.	Chi & Qu (2008)	10.1016/j.tourman.2007.06.007
	TS5	I am pleased with my overall travel experience in Nepal.	Chen & Tsai (2007)	10.1016/j.tourman.2006.07.007

Table 5 Continued

Construct	Code	Measurement Item	Adapted From	DOI
Revisit Intention	RI1	I intend to revisit Nepal in the future.	Prayag (2009)	10.1080/13683500802653345
	RI2	Nepal will be my first choice for a future holiday.	Chi & Qu (2008)	10.1016/j.tourman.2007.06.007
	RI3	I expect to revisit Nepal within the next few years.	Stylos et al. (2016)	10.1016/j.tourman.2015.09.006
	RI4	I would like to spend more holidays in Nepal.	Prayag (2009)	10.1080/13683500802653345
	RI5	I will revisit Nepal whenever I have the opportunity.	Stylos et al. (2016)	10.1016/j.tourman.2015.09.006
Recommendation Intention	REC1	I will recommend Nepal to my friends and relatives.	Chen & Tsai (2007)	10.1016/j.tourman.2006.07.007
	REC2	I will say positive things about Nepal to others.	Žabkar et al. (2010)	10.1016/j.tourman.2010.06.005
	REC3	I will encourage others to visit Nepal.	Chen & Tsai (2007)	10.1016/j.tourman.2006.07.007
	REC4	I would recommend Nepal as a holiday destination.	Žabkar et al. (2010)	10.1016/j.tourman.2010.06.005
	REC5	I will share my positive travel experience with others.	Chen & Tsai (2007)	10.1016/j.tourman.2006.07.007